

2c. Content of Psychological themes through core studies (Component 02)

Psychological themes through core studies (Component 02) aims to develop the critical thinking and independent learning skills essential to the scientific study of psychology through a focus on some of the key themes investigated within the subject. For each key theme, learners are presented with both a classic and a contemporary study.

The classic studies are 'landmark' pieces of research that have helped to shape the course of the subject and which all learners of psychology should become familiar with. The contemporary studies are more 'up-to-date' pieces of research that engage in some way with the issues being explored in the classic studies they are paired with.

Section A: Core studies

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This section will assess the learners' knowledge and understanding of the core studies as well as their ability to evaluate the studies both on their own and in relation to the study they have been paired with. The core studies are placed within a broad area of investigation. Within each area, the learners are required to examine four core studies. These core studies are paired together around key themes. For each key theme, the learners need to examine both a classic and a contemporary study. The classic studies have been carefully selected on the basis of their historical importance while the studies as a whole have been selected to represent a variety of research methodologies, designs, samples, sampling methods, issues and debates. For full references please see Appendix 5d.			
Area	Key theme	Classic study	Contemporary study
Social	Responses to people in authority	Milgram (1963) Obedience	Bocchiaro et al. (2012) Disobedience and whistle-blowing
	Responses to people in need	Piliavin et al. (1969) Subway Samaritan	Levine et al. (2001) Cross-cultural altruism
Cognitive	Attention	Moray (1959) Auditory attention	Simons and Chabris (1999) Visual inattention
	Memory	Loftus and Palmer (1974) Eyewitness testimony	Grant et al. (1998) Context-dependent memory
Developmental	External influences on children's behaviour	Bandura et al. (1961) Transmission of aggression	Watt et al. (2003) Funhaler study
	Moral development	Kohlberg (1968) Stages of moral development	Lee et al. (1997) Evaluations of lying and truth-telling
Biological	Regions of the brain	Sperry (1968) Split brain study	Casey et al. (2011) Neural correlates of delay of gratification
	Brain plasticity	Blakemore and Cooper (1970) Impact of early visual experience	Maguire et al. (2000) Taxi drivers

cont. Section A: Core studies			
Area	Key theme	Classic study	Contemporary study
Individual differences	Understanding disorders	Freud (1909) Little Hans	Baron-Cohen et al. (1997) Autism in adults
	Measuring differences	Gould (1982) A nation of morons Bias in IQ testing	Hancock et al. (2011) Language of psychopaths

Section A: Core Studies	Content
Individual studies	'Tell the story' of each core study in terms of: • background • method ○ design ○ sample ○ materials/apparatus ○ procedure • results • conclusions.
Core studies in their pairs	• How the two studies are similar. • How the two studies are different. • To what extent the contemporary study changes our understanding of the key theme.
Methodological issues	• The strengths and weaknesses of the different research methods and techniques. • The strengths and weaknesses of different types of data. • Ethical considerations. • Validity. • Reliability. • Sampling bias. • Ethnocentrism.
Key themes and areas of psychology	• How each core study relates to its key theme. • How each core study relates to the area of psychology it is placed within.